the pursuit of a personal ethics and the claims of a public, political life, *An Autobiography* is a challenge to our settled views. The idea of religion it expresses, and its conception of politics and public action, are profoundly original.

Gandhi first contemplated writing an autobiography in 1921, but he did not actually begin work on it until 1925, at the age of fifty-six. It initially took the form of a series of acticles, the first of which Gandhi published in December 1925 in his own newspaper, *Navajivan* (Young India). Published under the title 'The Story of My Experiments with Truth', the articles continued to appear until early 1929; collected together in book form, they were published in two volumes, the first appearing in 1927, and the second in 1929, and carried the additional title, *An Autobiography*.* In his 'Introduction', Gandhi describes in diffident terms how he came to write it, acceding finally to the urgings of his colleagues, and finding his parsimonious instincts satisfied by the fact that he could use these chapters to fill column inches in his newspaper. That he could turn to this task in the mid-1920s was in large part due to the Indian political situation. These were slack years in the Congress's political campaign, when the movement seemed to be losing its way. Gandhi decided to remove himself from the main lines of Indian politics, shunting himself to the siding of his Ashram at Sabarmati. This retreat followed what had been a period of remarkable personal success for Gandhi. He had arrived in India from South Africa with a reputation for integrity and hard work, but he was, in fact, virtually unknown beyond a narrow, elite circle. Yet, without any power base of his own, he had – through